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Window Guard User Guide

Version 0.6.0
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Window Guard is a small Windows program that hides selected application windows until you unlock them with a PIN. It remembers which apps are protected and relocks them when they close.

> **Important:** This is a privacy tool, not a Windows security feature. A user who can end the Window Guard process or modify its files can bypass it. Windows may also show a protected window briefly before Window Guard hides it.

1. What you need

- Windows 10 or 11.
- For the standalone EXE: no Python installation is needed.
- For the source version: Python 3.10 or newer, `pystray` and `Pillow`.

Install source dependencies with:

```
python -m pip install -r requirements.txt
```

2. Start Window Guard

If you're using the compiled version, run `WindowGuard.exe`. If you're using the source, run `run_window_guard.bat`, or:

```
python window_guard.py
```

The main window shows your protected programs and their current **Locked / Unlocked** and **Running / Not running** states.

3. Add a program

1. Open the Windows program you want to protect.
2. In Window Guard, choose **Add Running App**.
3. Find the window you want in the list and check its executable name and path.
4. Choose **Add Selected App**.

You can use **Browse EXE** instead, but selecting a running window is usually more reliable.

Firefox Portable: select the `firefox.exe` process that owns the browser window. The `FirefoxPortable.exe` launcher is not usually the right one.

If an app is not listed, open **Tools → Diagnostics** and check which process owns the visible window. Some elevated programs may require Window Guard to run with the same privileges.

4. Set or change the PIN

Open **Tools → Set / Change PIN**. Enter a PIN of **4 to 12 digits**, then confirm it. To change an existing PIN, enter the current one first.

The PIN is stored as a salted PBKDF2 hash, not as readable text. If you forget it, see the recovery section below.

5. Lock and unlock apps

Protected apps start out **Locked**. When Window Guard detects a window belonging to a locked app, it hides that window and displays a PIN prompt. Enter the correct PIN to restore the window.

Each application is handled separately. If Firefox is unlocked, Notepad++ can still be locked.

To lock apps manually:

- Select an app, then choose **Lock Selected App**.
- Use **File → Lock All Now**, the tray menu, or the optional keyboard shortcut to lock them all.

After you close an unlocked program **completely**, Window Guard returns it to **Locked**. Opening it again requires the PIN. Simply closing one window may not be enough if the program keeps background processes running.

6. What the app remembers

The protected-app list stays saved when apps close or Windows restarts. Apps start **Locked** when Window Guard starts; an unlocked state is only for the current running session.

Window Guard saves the list and settings here:

```
%APPDATA%\WindowGuard\config.json
```

Don’t share this file. It may contain application paths and PIN verification data.

7. System tray and Windows startup

If **Close main window to system tray** is enabled, clicking the main window’s **X** hides it instead of exiting. Right-click the tray icon for options such as **Show Window Guard**, **Lock All Now** and **Exit**.

Open **Tools** → **Settings** to enable **Start with Windows**. When you move the EXE to a new folder, turn this setting off and back on so Windows uses its new path.

To keep the main window hidden when Windows starts, enable **Start hidden when launched by Windows startup**.

8. Settings

Open **Tools** → **Settings**, make your changes and click **Save**.

Setting	What it changes
Start with Windows	Creates or removes a startup entry for your Windows account.
Close to tray	Hides the main window when you click X. When disabled, X exits.
Start hidden at Windows startup	Starts Window Guard without showing its main window.
Confirm removal	Asks before an app is removed from the protected list.
Global shortcut	Enables or disables **Ctrl+Shift+L** for Lock All.
Monitoring interval	Checks for protected app windows every **250, 350, 500 or 1000 ms**. Default: **350 ms**.

Auto-relocking after an app fully closes remains enabled.

9. Keyboard shortcut

Enable **Ctrl+Shift+L** in Settings if you want to lock apps without opening the Window Guard window. It's disabled by default.

If another program already uses that shortcut, Window Guard can't register it. Use the tray menu or **File → Lock All Now** instead.

10. Menus

Menu	Main commands
File	Lock All Now, hide to tray, exit
Applications	Add Running App, Browse EXE, Lock Selected App, Remove Selected
Tools	Set/Change PIN, Settings, Diagnostics, Export Diagnostics, open folders
GitHub	Open repository, Issues, Releases, Check for Updates
Help	HTML Help, PDF manual, About

GitHub → Check for Updates opens the project's Releases page in your browser. It doesn't download or install anything.

11. Diagnostics

If app detection doesn't work, open **Tools → Diagnostics**. It lists process names, IDs and visible window titles. Use **Export Diagnostics** to save the report as text.

Check the file before sharing it. Window titles and executable paths can contain your username, document names or other private information.

12. Build a portable EXE

Run `build_window_guard.bat` on Windows. It installs the build dependencies, runs PyInstaller and copies the manuals into `dist`.

```
dist/
  WindowGuard.exe
  WindowGuard_Help.html
  WindowGuard_Help.pdf
  README.md
  LICENSE
```

The `.ico` and `.png` icon files are bundled in the executable. The HTML and PDF manuals must stay beside the EXE for the Help menu to find them.

Run `hash_release.bat` after building if you need a SHA-256 hash for your GitHub release.

13. Troubleshooting

A protected program does not appear in the app picker. Make sure it has a visible window, then refresh the running-app list. Try Diagnostics. For portable applications, select the actual process rather than its launcher.

A program isn't hidden. Confirm its executable in Diagnostics. If it runs as administrator, Window Guard may need the same permission level.

The PIN dialog isn't showing. Check whether Window Guard is running in the tray. Confirm you've set a PIN. If the app is still running and was already unlocked, close its processes completely before testing relock-on-close.

A program's window flashes before hiding. That can happen. Window Guard checks windows periodically; it does not block the process from launching.

The tray icon isn't visible. Look in the notification-area overflow. If running from source, check that `pystray` and `Pillow` are installed.

Help doesn't open. Keep `WindowGuard_Help.html` and `WindowGuard_Help.pdf` next to `WindowGuard.exe`.

Start with Windows stopped working after moving the EXE. Disable and enable the setting again to update the saved path.

14. Forgotten PIN

There's no PIN recovery because the original PIN isn't stored. To reset the app, close Window Guard and remove:

```
%APPDATA%\WindowGuard\config.json
```

This also removes the protected-app list and saved settings. Make a copy of the file first if you need to preserve your configuration for troubleshooting.

15. Security limits

Window Guard hides windows. It does **not** prevent someone with enough Windows access from ending the program, changing its configuration or using other tools to open an app. It also cannot guarantee that a newly launched protected window is never briefly visible.

For locking the whole computer, use your Windows login and **Windows + L**.

Some antivirus products flag PyInstaller-built EXEs. You can inspect the source and build it yourself. Don't disable antivirus just to run Window Guard.

16. GitHub and source code

Source, release notes and issue reporting are available at:

github.com/Gexos/window-guard

The project is released under the **MIT License**. Check the `LICENSE` file for the terms.

The GitHub Actions Windows build workflow creates a downloadable build artifact. It does **not** automatically publish a GitHub release. Test each build before sharing it.

17. Adding screenshots to GitHub

Capture the real application from your Windows PC. Use **Windows + Shift + S** to take shots of the main window, app picker, PIN dialog and tray/Settings menu. Hide private paths, titles and PINs. Save the images in `docs/screenshots/` and follow that folder's `README.md` to update the main README.

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